

Resonant versus geometric anisotropy of the Purcell enhancement near a gold nanorod: plasmon-mode decomposition, an equal-volume control and design rules for single-photon sources

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Abstract

Near the tip of a gold nanorod the decay rate of a quantum emitter depends strongly on the orientation of its transition dipole. Part of this anisotropy is generic—any metal surface quenches a perpendicular dipole more strongly than a parallel one—and part is due to the longitudinal plasmon resonance of the elongated particle, but the two have not been separated quantitatively. We do so for a capped gold nanorod (length 60 nm, diameter 20 nm) with converged boundary-element calculations that reproduce the exact Mie solution for the equal-volume sphere to about 1 %, and with a quasistatic plasmon-eigenmode decomposition of the decay rate. At a 5 nm gap the axial dipole reaches a Purcell factor of 1.64×10^3 and a radiative enhancement of 117, and 91 % of the rate enhancement is carried by a single mode, the longitudinal dipolar plasmon. The remaining, non-resonant part has an axial-to-transverse ratio of about three, close to that of the equal-volume sphere (2.8–3.0); the resonance raises the ratio to 49 for the total and 329 for the radiative rate. Because the quenching background decays faster with distance than the coupling to the mode, the anisotropy is largest not at the smallest gap but at about 10 nm (136), and it grows with the aspect ratio from 19 to 872 between aspect ratios 2 and 5, while the non-resonant factor stays near three for all shapes. Translating the results into design rules, we show that the optimal gap grows with the intrinsic quantum yield of the emitter, quantify the tolerance to the emitter position, the effect of a glass substrate and of nonlocal response, and give resonance-matched antenna parameters for representative emitters. Three-dimensional and body-of-revolution finite-difference time-domain calculations agree with the boundary-element results for the radiative quantities but underestimate (by 9 %) or fail to converge for the total rate in the nanometre gap.

Keywords: Purcell effect; local density of optical states; gold nanorod; plasmon eigenmodes; quenching; single-photon source; boundary element method.

1 Introduction

The spontaneous emission rate of a quantum emitter is not an intrinsic property but depends on its electromagnetic environment [1, 2]. Metallic nanoparticles supporting localized surface plasmon resonances confine light to volumes far below the diffraction limit and can enhance emission rates by several orders of magnitude [3–5]. This has made plasmonic nanoantennas a candidate platform for bright, fast single-photon sources [6–9], in which a large rate enhancement shortens the excited-state lifetime and raises the achievable repetition rate, and a short radiative lifetime relative to the dephasing time is a prerequisite for indistinguishable photons [10].

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The price of plasmonic confinement is absorption. At emitter–metal separations of a few nanometres, energy is transferred to non-radiative channels in the metal, and the fluorescence is quenched rather than enhanced [11–14]. The total decay rate and the radiative rate therefore have to be treated separately, and their ratio—the antenna quantum efficiency—depends sensitively on distance, wavelength and the intrinsic quantum yield of the emitter [15–17].

Gold nanorods are attractive antennas because their longitudinal plasmon resonance is tunable through the aspect ratio across the visible and near infrared [18, 19], they can be synthesised with good control [20], and their tips concentrate the near field. Single-molecule experiments have demonstrated fluorescence enhancements exceeding a thousandfold near individual gold nanorods [21, 22], down to emitters with quantum yields of 10^{-4} [17]. On the theory side, Mohammadi *et al.* computed radiative enhancements and antenna efficiencies for gold nanorods and nanospheroids as a function of aspect ratio, volume and embedding medium [23, 24], and body-of-revolution solvers have recently been extended to excitation and emission near core–shell rods [25]. These studies, which exploit the rotational symmetry of an emitter on the rod axis, consider the axial dipole and gaps of 10 nm or more.

A consequence of the nanorod’s elongated shape is a strong dependence of the response on the orientation of the emitter’s transition dipole. Yet a dipole close to any metal surface—a sphere or a plane—also shows an orientation dependence: in the quasi-static near field, energy transfer to the metal is twice as strong for a dipole perpendicular to the surface as for a parallel one [13]. It is therefore not obvious how much of the anisotropy near a nanorod tip is generic and how much is caused by the longitudinal resonance that distinguishes the nanorod from a compact particle. The distinction matters in practice: emitters such as colloidal quantum dots, nanodiamonds or dye molecules are often randomly oriented, and orientation-averaged or scalar descriptions—a single “Purcell factor”—discard precisely the resonant part. A second, methodological issue is that the total rate in a nanometre gap is difficult to converge with volume-discretisation methods, whereas the radiative rate is not; conclusions about quenching then depend on the solver.

In this work we separate the two contributions in two independent ways. First, we compare the nanorod with an equal-volume gold sphere, probed with axial (radial) and transverse (tangential) dipoles at the same gap. Second, we expand the decay rate in the quasistatic plasmon eigenmodes of the particle [26] and isolate the contribution of the longitudinal dipolar mode from the non-resonant background. All rates are computed with a boundary-element method validated against the exact Mie solution, and checked against two finite-difference time-domain solvers. We then translate the results into design rules for plasmon-enhanced single-photon sources: the dependence of the optimal gap on the emitter’s intrinsic quantum yield, the tolerance to its position, the effect of a substrate and of nonlocal response, and resonance-matched antennas for representative emitters.

2 Theory

2.1 Decay rates and efficiency

For a point dipole $\mathbf{p} = p \hat{\mathbf{n}}$ at $\mathbf{r}_0$ in the weak-coupling regime, the total decay rate normalised to its value in the homogeneous host is [2]

$$\frac{\Gamma_{\text{tot}}}{\Gamma_0} = \frac{6\pi c}{\omega} \hat{\mathbf{n}} \cdot \text{Im} \overleftrightarrow{\mathbf{G}}(\mathbf{r}_0, \mathbf{r}_0; \omega) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}} \equiv F_p(\omega), \quad (1)$$

where $\overleftrightarrow{\mathbf{G}}$ is the dyadic Green function. Classically, $F_p = P_{\text{tot}}/P_0$ is the power delivered by a constant-amplitude dipole relative to the homogeneous host. The power radiated to the far field, $T = P_{\text{rad}}/P_0$, gives the radiative enhancement, and $F_p - T$ is absorbed in the metal. For an emitter of intrinsic quantum yield q_0 , the quantum efficiency in the presence of the antenna is [15]

$$\eta(q_0) = \frac{T}{F_p + (1 - q_0)/q_0}, \quad (2)$$

which reduces to the antenna efficiency $\eta_a = T/F_p$ for $q_0 = 1$. The total decay rate of the emitter is multiplied by $q_0 F_p + 1 - q_0$.

For a dipole on the symmetry axis of a body of revolution the Green tensor is diagonal, with an axial component and two equal transverse ones; the anisotropy is fully characterised by the ratios $F_p^\parallel/F_p^\perp$ and $T^\parallel/T^\perp$. For a sphere, axial and transverse correspond to radial and tangential dipoles, for which exact Mie expressions exist [27–29]. The equal-volume sphere therefore provides a reference that has the same amount of gold and the same dipole–surface gap, but no elongated resonance.

2.2 Plasmon-eigenmode decomposition

In the quasistatic limit the surface charge σ induced on a particle obeys the boundary integral equation $(\Lambda + F)\sigma = -\phi'_{\text{ext}}$, where F is the normal derivative of the Coulomb kernel on the surface, ϕ'_{ext} the normal derivative of the external (dipole) potential, and $\Lambda(\omega) = 2\pi(\varepsilon + \varepsilon_b)/(\varepsilon - \varepsilon_b)$ contains the permittivities of the metal and the host [26, 30]. Expanding in the right and left eigenvectors of F , $Fu_k = \lambda_k u_k$, $\tilde{u}_k F = \lambda_k \tilde{u}_k$, $\tilde{u}_k u_l = \delta_{kl}$, gives

$$\sigma = -\sum_k \frac{u_k (\tilde{u}_k \cdot \phi'_{\text{ext}})}{\Lambda(\omega) + \lambda_k}, \quad F_p - 1 = \sum_k \Delta F_p^{(k)}, \quad (3)$$

because the induced field at the dipole, and hence $F_p - 1$, is linear in σ . Each mode resonates where $\text{Re } \Lambda(\omega) = -\lambda_k$, and its weight is the product of its coupling to the dipole ($\tilde{u}_k \cdot \phi'_{\text{ext}}$) and of the field it produces back at the dipole. For the rod, the longitudinal dipolar mode is identified as the eigenvector with the largest axial oscillator strength. On the axis, it couples only to the axial dipole, whereas the transverse dipole couples only to modes with azimuthal number $m = \pm 1$. We call $\Delta F_p^{(L)}$ the resonant part and $F_p - 1 - \Delta F_p^{(L)}$ the background; the background contains the high-order modes that accumulate near the surface-plasmon condition and describe the lossy-surface (quenching) channel [11, 13].

3 Methods

3.1 Geometry and material

The nanorod is a gold cylinder of length 40 nm and radius $R = 10$ nm terminated by two hemispherical caps (total length $L = 60$ nm, aspect ratio 3), a geometry accessible by seed-mediated growth [20]. The dipole is placed on the rod axis at a distance d from the apex ($d = 5$ nm unless stated otherwise; 3–30 nm in the gap study). The equal-volume sphere has $R_{\text{sph}} = 15.874$ nm. The host is air unless stated. Gold is described by the tabulated Johnson–Christy permittivity [31] in all boundary-element and Mie calculations.

3.2 Boundary-element method

The rates are computed with the boundary-element method (BEM) of the MNPBEM17 toolbox [30, 32, 33], which solves the full Maxwell equations for the surface charges and currents and discretises only the particle boundary, with curved boundary elements. F_p follows from the induced field at the dipole and T from the far field, both in units of the rate in the homogeneous host. The rod surface is discretised with element sizes $h = 3, 2$ and 1.5 nm (720, 1550 and 2829 elements), the sphere with 400, 784 and 1444 vertices; all gaps of one geometry are solved simultaneously. The eigenmode decomposition, Eq. (3), uses the 40 lowest quasistatic eigenmodes of the 2 nm mesh; the full quasistatic F_p is computed with the same mesh. Additional calculations, described where they are used, include a glass substrate (layer Green function [32]), the hydrodynamic nonlocal response through the equivalent local cover layer of Luo *et al.* [34], plane-wave excitation, other shapes and silver. All calculations ran on GitHub-hosted runners; the scripts are provided.

3.3 Finite-difference time-domain cross-checks

The rod and sphere were also computed with a commercial three-dimensional FDTD solver (Lumerical FDTD 2024 R1, 2 nm override mesh) [35, 36] and with a body-of-revolution FDTD in cylindrical coordinates (Meep [37], grids of 2, 1.33 and 1 nm), in which an axial dipole couples only to the $m = 0$ field harmonic. Details, the gold Drude–Lorentz fit required by the time-domain solvers and all benchmarks are given in the Supplementary Information.

4 Results

4.1 Validation and convergence

For the equal-volume sphere at a 5 nm gap the BEM reproduces the exact Mie solution for both dipole orientations over 500–900 nm (Fig. 3): with 1444 vertices the median deviation is 0.9 % for the radial F_p and 1.4 % for the radial T , 0.7 % and 1.0 % for the tangential dipole, and at most 4 %; the deviation is of the same size at 10 and 20 nm and in water (Table S1). For the rod (axial dipole, 5 nm gap) the peak values change by 0.3 % (F_p) and 0.4 % (T) between the two finest meshes, and the peak positions not at all (Table S2, Fig. S1); we quote the 1.5 nm mesh. The three-dimensional FDTD reproduces the radiative peak (119 at 616 nm, BEM 117 at 608 nm) but gives a 9 % lower F_p (1496 versus 1638); the body-of-revolution FDTD reproduces T to 7 % on a 1 nm grid but does not converge for F_p in the 5 nm gap, where the staircased surface overestimates it by about a factor of two even for the sphere (Supplementary Information). Volume discretisation is therefore adequate for the radiated power and the emission pattern, but the total rate—and hence the quenching—in a nanometre gap requires a method that represents the metal surface exactly.

4.2 Axial versus transverse dipole, rod versus sphere

Figure 1 shows F_p , T and η_a at a 5 nm gap. For the axial dipole at the rod tip F_p peaks at 1638 at 604 nm and T at 117 at 608 nm, where $\eta_a = 7.3$ %: more than 92 % of the energy is absorbed. A second F_p maximum at 512 nm (848) coincides with the onset of interband absorption and is almost purely non-radiative ($T = 2.0$). The transverse dipole at the same position has $T < 0.5$ at all wavelengths—it radiates less than in free space—and its F_p maximum (248 at 508 nm) is non-radiative.

The equal-volume sphere separates the generic from the resonant contribution (Fig. 2). Its radial-to-tangential ratio of F_p lies between 2.75 and 2.97 over the whole band, in agreement with the exact solution (2.76–2.97) and near the quasi-static flat-surface value of two, without resonant structure. The rod shows a similar ratio (3.3–4.0) below 530 nm but rises to 49 at the longitudinal resonance. For the radiated power the sphere ratio is 11–53, varying slowly with wavelength, because a tangential dipole near a metal surface radiates poorly; the rod ratio is 5–6 below 530 nm and 329 at resonance. At 608 nm the rod exceeds the sphere by factors of 15 in F_p and 23 in T , whereas the maxima of the two particles differ by only 2.0 in F_p : with the same amount of gold, the elongated particle does not provide a larger total rate but moves a radiative resonance out of the interband region.

4.3 Mode decomposition

The eigenmode analysis makes this separation explicit (Fig. 4). The lowest non-trivial mode of the rod is the longitudinal dipole ($\lambda_k = -5.01$, quasistatic resonance at 595 nm, 13 nm to the blue of the retarded result); the transverse dipolar modes lie at $\lambda_k \approx -1.71$, which requires $\varepsilon \approx -1.75$ and therefore falls into the strongly damped interband region below 500 nm. At a 5 nm gap and the resonance, 91 % of $F_p - 1$ is carried by the longitudinal mode alone. The remaining background is a smooth function of wavelength and its axial value exceeds the transverse rate

Table 1: Quantum efficiency $\eta(q_0)$ at the radiative peak of the rod (axial dipole, BEM), Eq. (2).

gap (nm)	λ_T (nm)	$F_p(\lambda_T)$	$T_{\max}$	$q_0 = 0.01$	0.1	0.5	1
3	608	3265	214.1	0.064	0.065	0.066	0.066
5	608	1600	116.5	0.069	0.072	0.073	0.073
7	612	831	69.2	0.074	0.082	0.083	0.083
10	612	407	36.1	0.071	0.087	0.089	0.089
15	612	155	15.5	0.061	0.095	0.100	0.100
20	612	71	8.2	0.048	0.103	0.114	0.116

by a factor of 3.1, close to the sphere’s ratio: *the geometric anisotropy of the rod is that of any curved metal surface, and the excess is the contribution of a single resonant mode.*

The two contributions depend differently on the gap (Fig. 4b,c). The background decays as the near-field of a dipole above a lossy surface, approximately as d^{-3} , whereas the coupling to the dipolar mode decays on the length scale of the tip radius. The share of the dipolar mode therefore increases from 80 % at 3 nm to 96 % at 10 nm and 98 % at 20 nm, and the total anisotropy $F_p^{\parallel}/F_p^{\perp}$ is non-monotonic: in the full retarded calculation it is 19 at 3 nm, 49 at 5 nm, 136 at 10 nm, 128 at 15 nm and 75 at 20 nm. At small gaps the quenching background, which both orientations share, dilutes the resonant contribution; at large gaps the transverse rate approaches its free-space value while the coupling to the mode keeps decreasing. The same decomposition for aspect ratios 2–5 and for the sphere (Fig. 4b, Table S3) shows that the background ratio is a property of the curved metal surface rather than of the shape: it is 2.5–3.7 for all four rods and 2.3–2.4 for the sphere at gaps of 3–10 nm. What changes with the shape is the weight of the dipolar mode. For the sphere its resonance lies in the interband region and it carries only 9 % of $F_p - 1$ at 5 nm; for the rods its share at 5 nm rises from 57 % (aspect ratio 2) to 91 %, 98 % and 99 % (aspect ratios 3, 4, 5), as the resonance moves away from the interband edge and gains oscillator strength. In the retarded calculation the maximum anisotropy, always found near 10 nm, accordingly grows from 19 (aspect ratio 2) to 54, 136, 621 and 872 (aspect ratios 2.5, 3, 4, 5).

4.4 Gap dependence and the quantum-yield design rule

Increasing the gap from 3 to 20 nm (Fig. 5) leaves the radiative peak at 608–612 nm while F_p falls from 3782 (at the interband maximum, 508 nm) to 78 and T from 214 to 8.2. The antenna efficiency at the radiative peak increases only from 6.6 % to 11.6 %, whereas its spectral maximum, reached far to the red of the resonance, rises from 12 % to 60 %. The exact solution for the sphere shows the same trade-off (Fig. 5, lower row).

For a single-photon source the relevant figure of merit depends on the operating regime. Under saturated (continuous-wave or high-repetition) excitation the photon rate scales with the radiative rate, i.e. with T , for any q_0 . Under pulsed excitation with a period much longer than the excited-state lifetime the number of photons per pulse scales with $\eta(q_0)$, Eq. (2) [6, 7]. Figure 6 and Table 1 show that the optimal gap depends on q_0 . For $q_0 = 1$ the 20 nm gap is best (11.6 %) and the 3 nm gap worst (6.6 %). For $q_0 = 0.01$ the order is reversed beyond 7 nm: gaps of 7 and 10 nm raise the efficiency from 1 % to 7.4 % and 7.1 %, whereas 20 nm gives 4.8 %. A large F_p is needed to outcompete the intrinsic non-radiative rate $(1 - q_0)/q_0$, but beyond that point additional F_p only feeds absorption, so the optimal gap increases with q_0 .

4.5 Excitation

Fluorescence below saturation is also proportional to the excitation rate, i.e. to the local intensity $|\mathbf{E} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{n}}|^2/|\mathbf{E}_0|^2$ at the emitter. For plane-wave illumination polarised along the rod axis the axial intensity enhancement at a 5 nm gap peaks at 119 at 610 nm (Fig. S2), equal within 2 % to the

radiative enhancement $T = 117$ at 608 nm, as expected from reciprocity for a dipolar antenna [2, 5]. At common pump wavelengths it is small: 3.2 at 405 nm, 3.0 at 450 nm and 1.8 at 532 nm, compared with 3.9, 3.9 and 6.7 for the sphere, whose resonance lies near 530 nm. Unless the emitter is pumped near the longitudinal resonance—for example through an upper level of a molecule or quasi-resonantly for a quantum dot—the rod accelerates and redirects emission but contributes little to excitation; for emitters pumped far above the gap the excitation enhancement is set by the interband response and is no larger than for a compact particle.

4.6 Robustness: emitter position, substrate and nonlocal response

Emitter position. [offset paragraph]

Substrate. In experiments the rod usually lies on a glass cover slip. We placed the rod with its axis parallel to a glass half-space ($n = 1.52$) at a height of 1 nm (a ligand layer) and the dipole beyond the tip, on the rod axis and parallel to the interface. The longitudinal resonance shifts from 608 to 635 nm; at a 5 nm gap the radiated power rises to 266 and F_p to 2198 (both in units of the vacuum rate), and the antenna efficiency increases from 7.3 % to 12.1 % (14.3 % and 17.6 % at 10 and 20 nm). Relative to the same dipole on bare glass, whose rate is 1.27 times the vacuum rate, the enhancements are 209 (T) and 1.7×10^3 (F_p). The substrate therefore does not weaken the conclusions; it improves the efficiency, because the resonance moves further from the interband edge, and a dipole parallel to and close to a glass interface radiates predominantly into the glass [2], i.e. towards an oil-immersion objective (we did not resolve the angular distribution with the substrate). The dipoles perpendicular to the rod axis remain dark ($T < 2.3$).

Nonlocal response. [nonlocal paragraph]

4.7 Generality: aspect ratio, environment, size, shape and metal

Figure 7 shows the radiative enhancement and the antenna efficiency at the radiative peak for aspect ratios 2–5 ($D = 20$ nm) and for the aspect-ratio-3 rod in water. As the resonance moves from 560 nm to 760 nm, T at a 5 nm gap rises from 18 to 1.0×10^3 and η_a from 2.5 % to 22.5 %, because the resonance leaves the interband region; in water the same rod resonates at 715 nm with $T = 457$ and $\eta_a = 19.8$ %. These trends agree with those found by Mohammadi *et al.* at a 10 nm distance [23]; the efficiency at the radiative peak depends mainly on the resonance wavelength and only weakly on the gap between 5 and 20 nm. At fixed aspect ratio 3, the rod volume matters: for diameters of 15, 20 and 30 nm the efficiency at the radiative peak (5 nm gap) is 3.3 %, 7.3 % and 23.7 %, reflecting the growth of radiative damping with volume, while the resonance shifts only from 605 to 625 nm; [D25 and spheroid]. A silver rod of the same dimensions resonates at 505 nm with $T = 1.1 \times 10^3$ and $\eta_a = 38$ %, and its anisotropy reaches 677 in F_p . In all gold cases the non-resonant ratio, read at 500 nm, is 2.9–3.8 at a 5 nm gap, so the separation into a geometric factor of about three and a resonant factor that grows with the oscillator strength of the longitudinal mode holds generally.

4.8 Collection efficiency

The near-to-far-field transformation of the body-of-revolution FDTD runs gives the fraction of the radiated power emitted into a cone around the rod axis; unlike F_p , this quantity is grid-independent. At the radiative peak it is 1.2 % for NA = 0.5 and 18.0 % for NA = 0.9, within 7 % of a bare axial dipole (1.3 % and 19.4 %): the antenna multiplies the radiated power by two orders of magnitude but does not redirect it, in contrast to multi-element antennas that are designed for directivity [38]. A rod standing along the optical axis of the collection objective therefore wastes most of its enhancement, whereas a rod lying in the focal plane presents a dipole perpendicular to the optical axis, for which the dipolar pattern gives about 33 % at NA = 0.9.

Table 2: Resonance-matched gold nanorods ($D = 20$ nm, air, axial dipole) for representative emitters. L : rod length maximising T at the emission wavelength λ_e ; speed-up: total decay rate relative to the bare emitter, $q_0 F_p + 1 - q_0$; η : Eq. (2).

emitter	λ_e (nm)	q_0	L (nm)	gap (nm)	T	speed-up	η	η/q_0
hBN defect [39]	580	0.87	50	5	46	950	4.2%	0.05
				20	3.9	39	8.8%	0.10
crystal violet [22]	640	0.02	60	5	58	10	11.2%	5.6
				20	5.7	1.4	7.8%	3.9
NV, 25 nm diamond [40]	690	0.10	80	5	436	222	19.6%	2.0
				20	30	14	21.7%	2.2
NV, 100 nm diamond [40]	690	0.70	80	5	436	1551	19.7%	0.28
CsPbI ₃ nanocrystal [41]	690	0.90	80	5	436	1993	19.7%	0.22
				20	30	116	23.2%	0.26

4.9 Design table for representative emitters

Table 2 combines the aspect-ratio sweep with literature values of the emission wavelength and the intrinsic quantum yield of four emitter classes: defects in hexagonal boron nitride ($q_0 = 0.87$ at 580 nm [39]), the dye crystal violet used in single-molecule nanorod experiments ($q_0 = 0.02$ [22]), NV centres in nanodiamonds, whose q_0 ranges from below 0.2 in 25 nm crystals to 0.1–0.9 in 100 nm crystals [40], and CsPbI₃ nanocrystals ($q_0 \approx 0.9$ [41]). For each emitter the rod length is chosen to maximise T at the emission wavelength. Three conclusions follow. First, the rate speed-up $q_0 F_p + 1 - q_0$ ranges from 10 to 2×10^3 and is largest for bright emitters, for which it is also accompanied by a loss of efficiency ($\eta/q_0 = 0.05$ – 0.33): for a near-unity emitter a gold nanorod is a device for speed and saturated brightness (through T), not for efficiency. Second, for poor emitters such as crystal violet the antenna improves the efficiency itself, by a factor of 5.6 at gaps of 5–10 nm. Third, the emission wavelength matters more than the gap: an emitter at 690 nm coupled to a rod resonating at 675 nm reaches $\eta_a \approx 20\%$ and $T > 400$, five times the radiative enhancement available at 580 nm, where interband absorption limits both.

5 Discussion

The central result is that the orientation dependence of emission near a nanorod tip consists of two factors with different physical origins. A non-resonant factor of about three, which is the same for the equal-volume sphere and for rods of aspect ratio 2–5, describes how strongly the curved metal surface quenches a perpendicular relative to a parallel dipole; it does not depend on the plasmon resonance. On top of it, a single mode—the longitudinal dipolar plasmon—contributes a resonant factor that grows with the oscillator strength of that mode, from 19 to 872 between aspect ratios 2 and 5. The eigenmode decomposition and the equal-volume control lead independently to the same separation, and the decomposition explains why the anisotropy peaks at an intermediate gap: the background is shared by both orientations and dominates at small gaps, while the coupling to the mode decays more slowly.

For randomly oriented emitters on the axis, the averages are $\langle F_p \rangle = (F_p^\parallel + 2F_p^\perp)/3$ and likewise for T . At 608 nm and a 5 nm gap this gives $\langle F_p \rangle = 555$ and $\langle T \rangle = 39$, three times below the axial values, while $\langle T \rangle / \langle F_p \rangle = 7.0\%$ is almost the axial efficiency because the axial channel dominates both averages. The ensemble is bimodal: one third of the orientations is bright, while the transverse two thirds are quenched ($\eta_a = 1.1\%$) and radiate less than in free space ($T = 0.35$). An enhancement factor measured on an orientation ensemble [21, 22] therefore hides a population of nearly dark emitters, which matters for single-emitter applications where each emitter’s orientation is fixed, and it suggests orientation-selective assembly or emitters with

a well-defined transition dipole.

For single-photon sources the results translate into simple rules. The gap should be chosen according to the emitter: 5–10 nm for poor emitters, for which the antenna raises the efficiency, and 15 nm or more for near-unity emitters, for which the antenna mainly accelerates the emission and raises the saturated photon rate at the cost of efficiency. The emission wavelength should lie well to the red of the interband edge, above about 650 nm for gold, which also favours longer rods, larger diameters and a glass substrate. The excitation should be resonant with the longitudinal mode if an excitation enhancement is wanted. Finally, because the antenna leaves the dipolar emission pattern intact, the rod should lie in the focal plane of the collection optics.

Methodologically, our comparison shows that volume-discretisation solvers reproduce the radiated power, the resonance and the emission pattern of a nanorod antenna but not the total rate in a 5 nm gap. A three-dimensional FDTD calculation with a conformal mesh underestimated it by 9%; a staircased body-of-revolution FDTD overestimated it by a factor of two even on a 1 nm grid. Statements about quenching, efficiency and the optimal gap therefore require a surface method or careful convergence studies.

The limitations of the present study are the local-response description of gold beyond the hydrodynamic estimate, which is adequate at gaps of a few nanometres but not in sub-nanometre gaps where tunnelling matters [42, 43]; surface scattering, which adds to the damping of small particles [44, 45]; the classical treatment of the emitter in the weak-coupling regime; and the quasistatic approximation of the eigenmode analysis, which shifts the longitudinal resonance by 13 nm and, lacking radiative coupling, gives anisotropy ratios about 35 % lower than the retarded ones (33, 82 and 47 versus 49, 136 and 75 at 5, 10 and 20 nm) while reproducing their gap dependence and the position of the maximum. A quasinormal-mode treatment [46, 47] would extend the decomposition to the retarded problem.

6 Conclusion

Using converged boundary-element calculations, an equal-volume sphere as a control and a plasmon-eigenmode decomposition, we have separated the orientational anisotropy of the Purcell enhancement near a gold nanorod tip into a geometric factor of about three, common to all curved metal surfaces, and a resonant factor carried by the longitudinal dipolar mode, which reaches 49 in the total and 329 in the radiative rate for an aspect-ratio-3 rod at a 5 nm gap, peaks near a 10 nm gap and grows with the aspect ratio. More than 92 % of the emitted power is absorbed at the Purcell maximum for a 5 nm gap; the optimal gap for a single-photon source depends on the intrinsic quantum yield of the emitter, and resonance-matched rods emitting above 650 nm, on glass and in the focal plane of the collection optics, offer the best compromise between speed, brightness and efficiency. Simulation scripts, raw spectra and analysis code are openly available.

Data availability

All raw spectra, simulation scripts (MNPBEM, Lumerical and Meep) and analysis code are available at <https://github.com/aminsadidi/maghale> (a Zenodo DOI will be assigned at publication).

Author contributions

[to be completed by the authors.]

Conflict of interest

The authors declare no competing interests.

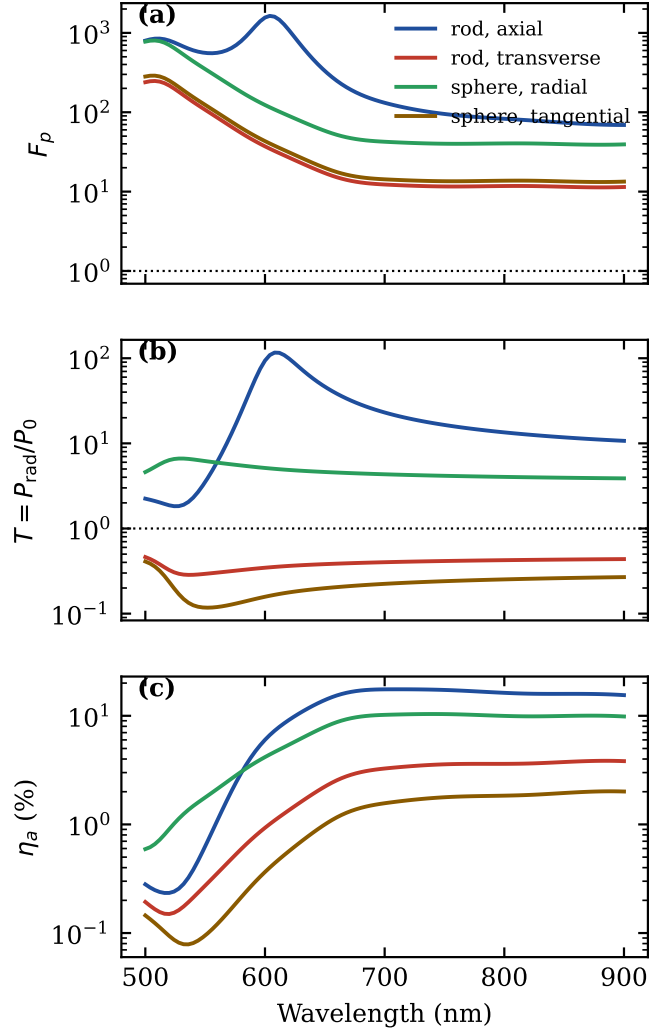


Figure 1: (a) Purcell factor, (b) radiative enhancement and (c) antenna efficiency at a 5 nm gap for the rod with axial and transverse dipole and the equal-volume sphere with radial and tangential dipole (BEM). Dotted: free space.

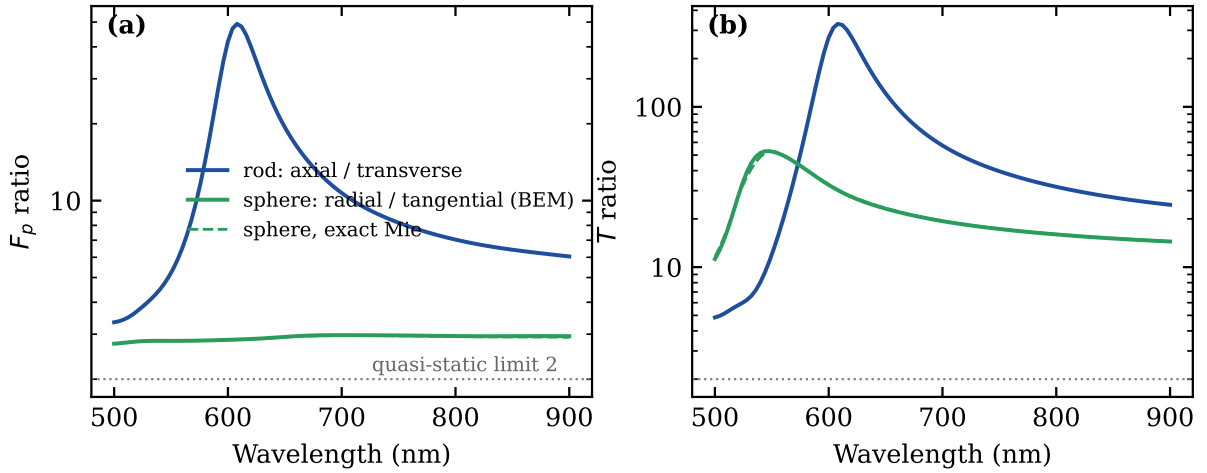


Figure 2: Orientation ratios of (a) F_p and (b) T for the rod (axial/transverse) and the equal-volume sphere (radial/tangential) at a 5 nm gap; dashed: exact Mie solution for the sphere. Dotted: quasi-static flat-surface limit of 2.

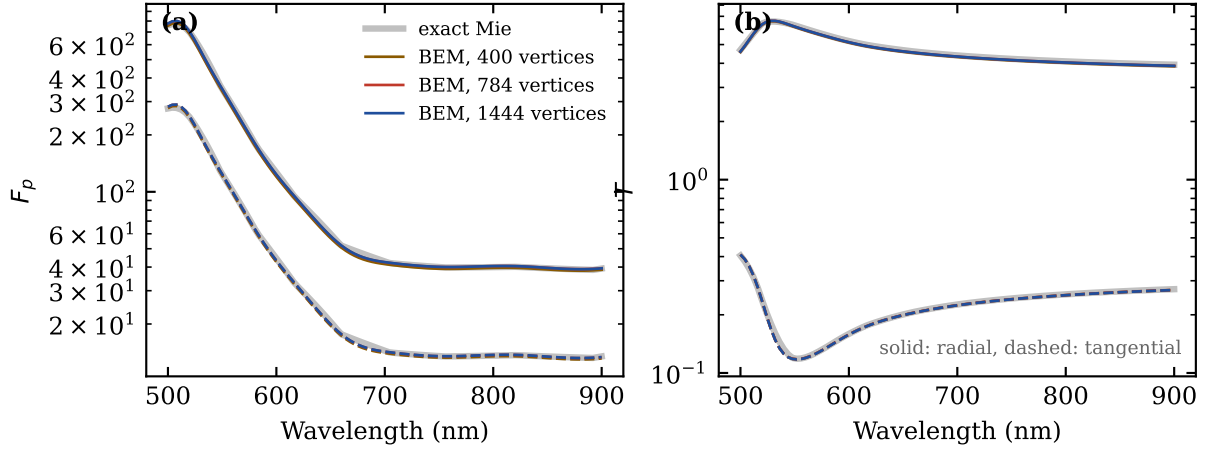


Figure 3: Validation of the BEM against the exact Mie solution for the equal-volume sphere at a 5 nm gap: (a) F_p and (b) T for the radial (solid) and tangential (dashed) dipole and three surface meshes. The thick grey curves are the exact results.

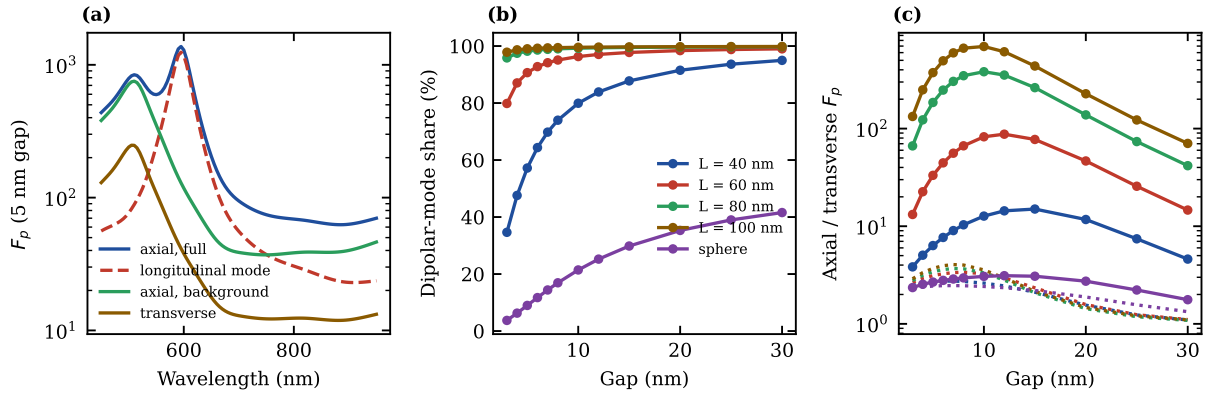


Figure 4: Plasmon-eigenmode decomposition (quasistatic BEM). (a) F_p of the axial dipole at a 5 nm gap, the contribution of the longitudinal dipolar mode, the remaining background and the transverse F_p . (b) Share of $F_p - 1$ carried by the longitudinal dipolar mode at its resonance versus gap. (c) Axial/transverse ratio of F_p (solid) and of the background alone (dotted) versus gap.

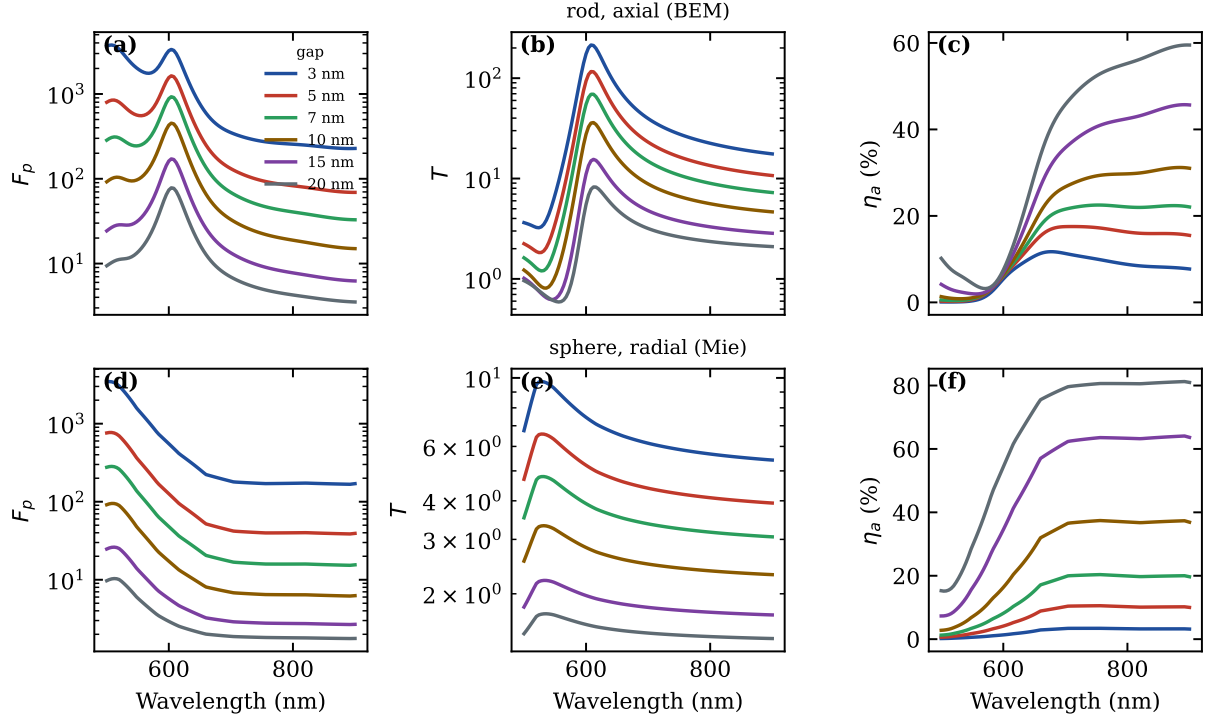


Figure 5: Gap dependence of F_p , T and η_a for the rod with axial dipole (top, BEM) and the equal-volume sphere with radial dipole (bottom, exact Mie).

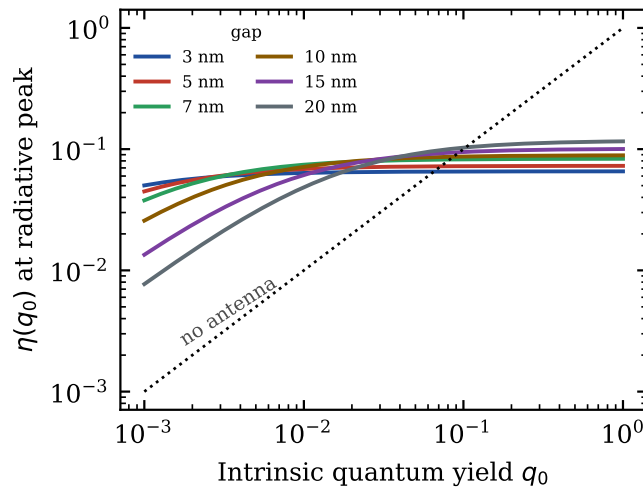


Figure 6: Quantum efficiency at the radiative peak versus intrinsic quantum yield, Eq. (2), for six gaps. Dotted: emitter without antenna ($\eta = q_0$).

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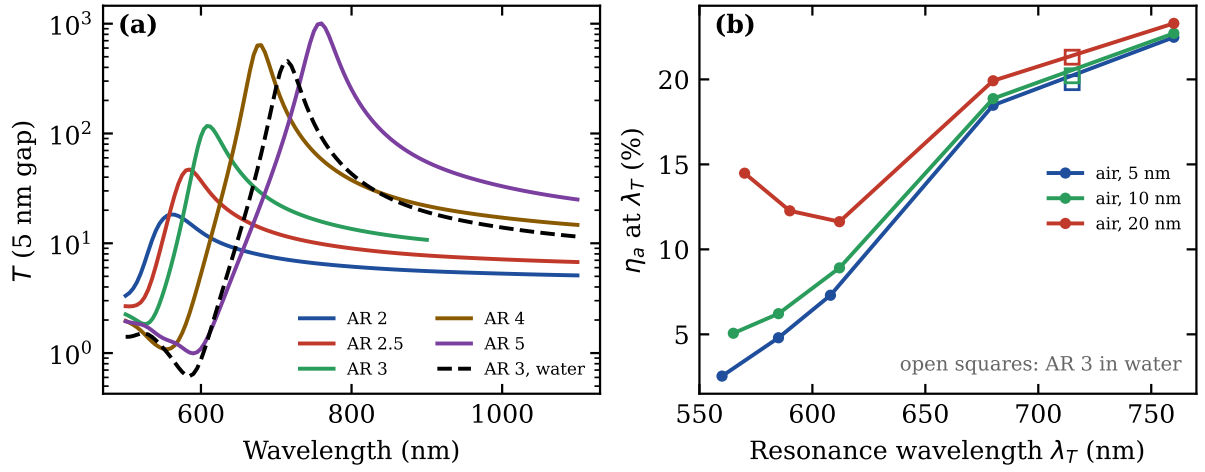


Figure 7: (a) Radiative enhancement of the axial dipole at a 5 nm gap for rods with $D = 20$ nm and aspect ratios (AR) 2–5 in air and AR 3 in water (BEM). (b) Antenna efficiency at the radiative peak versus resonance wavelength for three gaps; open squares: AR 3 in water.